

AKHS TRADERS

Rice Export — Pakistan to DRC & Middle East

50 Questions to Ask an Experienced Rice Exporter

A complete guide for new exporters — Registration, Bank, Buyers, Mills & Shipping

- Step 1: Registration & Certificates
- Step 2: Bank / LC / Payment
- Step 3: Finding Buyers
- Step 4: Mill / Supplier Deals
- Step 5: Shipping / Freight

STEP 1 **Registration & Certificates**

Ask about the correct order, documents, costs and mistakes

1**Which registrations did you do FIRST — what is the correct order?**

PSW first? REAP first? NTN first? What is the right sequence?

2**How long did PSW registration take — any problems?**

What documents did they reject? What mistakes should I avoid?

3**REAP membership — is it really mandatory or can you skip it early?**

How much is the annual fee? Who to contact in Gujranwala/Karachi?

4**Do you need TDAP registration before first shipment or after?**

Is it useful or just extra paperwork?

5**Phytosanitary Certificate — who issues it, how many days, what is the cost?**

Which DPP office — Lahore or Karachi? Any rejections experienced?

6**Certificate of Origin — FPCCI or Chamber of Commerce — which does your buyer accept?**

Some Middle East buyers want FPCCI specifically.

7**SGS / COTECNA quality inspection — does your buyer demand it or is it optional?**

Who pays — you or buyer? How much does it cost per container?

8**Fumigation Certificate — which company do you use, how much per container?**

Phosphine fumigation — how many days before loading?

9**Do you have a sample of your complete document set for one shipment?**

Ask to see: Invoice, Packing List, B/L, COO, Phyto, Fumigation, SGS — all together.

10**Did you face any problem at Karachi port customs — what was the reason?**

Learn from his mistakes before you make your own.

STEP 2 Bank / LC / Payment

Ask about ESFCA, LC process, payment terms and cash flow

1

Which bank did you open your ESFCA account in — which bank is best?

HBL? MCB? UBL? Which one processes export LCs fastest?

2

When LC comes to your bank — what is the first thing you do?

Do you check LC terms yourself or give it straight to bank officer?

3

What LC discrepancies did you face — what mistakes cause LC rejection?

Wrong description, wrong HS code, wrong port name — learn his errors.

4

How many days does your bank take to negotiate the LC after shipment?

When do you actually receive the money in your account?

5

Do your buyers pay LC at sight or 30/60/90 days deferred?

Middle East = mostly LC at sight. DRC = sometimes 30–60 days.

6

Do you accept TT (bank transfer) from any buyer or only LC?

New exporters often get burned by TT — ask his opinion.

7

SBP 50% rule — how do you manage it practically?

50% must stay in ESFCA — how does he handle cash flow?

8

What is your bank's export LC processing fee per shipment?

Banks charge for LC advising, negotiation, SWIFT — know the costs.

9

Did you ever have a buyer refuse to pay — how did you protect yourself?

Confirmed LC? Freight forwarder holding B/L? What protection method?

10

How much working capital did you need for your first container?

Mill payment before shipment — how many days gap before you get paid?

STEP 3 Finding Buyers

Ask about where to find real buyers, verify them and build relationships

1

Where did you find your first buyer — Alibaba, WhatsApp, trade fair or personal contact?

Most Pakistan rice exporters find first buyer through personal network — ask his story.

2

How do you verify a buyer is real and not a scammer?

What do you check — company registration, physical address, references?

3

Do you use a broker/agent in DRC or Middle East — or direct buyer only?

Brokers take 1–3% commission — is it worth it for a new exporter?

4

Which city in DRC has the most rice importers — Kinshasa or Matadi?

Where to find serious buyers with import license.

5

Which WhatsApp groups or trade networks do you use for rice buyers?

Ask him to add you — this is gold for a new exporter.

6

How many containers did your first buyer order — what was the minimum?

1 container? 5 containers? What is realistic for a first deal?

7

Do your buyers visit Pakistan to inspect rice — or they trust samples?

Some DRC buyers come to Lahore/Karachi — be prepared.

8

How do you send rice samples — courier cost, how much quantity?

DHL/FedEx to Kinshasa — how much does it cost, how many kg sample?

9

What is the biggest complaint your DRC/Middle East buyers had about your rice?

Moisture? Broken %? Foreign matter? Color? Learn before you ship.

10

Can you introduce me to one of your buyers or give me a reference contact?

If he trusts you — this one question can change everything.

STEP 4 Mill / Supplier Deals

Ask about selecting mills, payment terms, agreements and quality control

1

How do you find a reliable mill — what is your selection criteria?

Capacity? ISO? SGS approved? Export experience? Ask his checklist.

2

Do you work with one mill only or multiple mills — which is better for a new exporter?

Single mill = easier relationship. Multiple mills = price competition.

3

What is the payment terms with your mill — advance, 50/50, or credit?

Most mills demand 50% advance — does he negotiate credit after trust builds?

4

How many days advance do you place order before shipment date?

Rice processing takes 7–15 days — when to book mill vs when to book container?

5

What is written in your mill agreement — what clauses protect you?

Quality guarantee? Penalty for delay? Replacement of rejected lot?

6

If SGS inspection fails at mill — who bears the cost, you or mill?

This is critical — get it in writing before first order.

7

What moisture % and broken % do you specify in mill agreement?

Buyer wants max 13.5% moisture, max 25% broken — does mill guarantee this?

8

Do you visit the mill yourself before each shipment or trust them blindly?

How many times did rice quality differ from what was agreed?

9

Which mills in Gujranwala or Karachi do you recommend for IRRI-6 export quality?

This one answer can save you months of searching.

10

What is the biggest problem you faced with a mill — and how did you solve it?

Short weight? Wrong grade? Late delivery? Learn his worst experience.

STEP 5 Shipping / Freight

Ask about shipping lines, clearing agents, costs and real transit experience

1

Which shipping line do you use for DRC — MSC or Maersk or someone else?

Who gives best rate and fastest sailing for Karachi to Matadi?

2

Do you book container directly with shipping line or through freight forwarder?

Direct = cheaper. Forwarder = easier for beginners — ask his recommendation.

3

What is the current freight rate Karachi to Matadi per 20ft container?

2025 rate — this changes monthly, get real number from him.

4

Who is your clearing agent in Karachi — can you recommend one?

A trusted clearing agent reference is worth more than anything — ask directly.

5

How much does clearing agent charge per container — all inclusive?

Port charges + GD filing + documentation — total cost in PKR.

6

How many days before sailing date do you need to submit documents to port?

Cut-off dates for booking, VGM, documentation — what is the timeline?

7

Do you take Marine Insurance — which company, how much per container?

Insurance cost + is it mandatory for DRC buyers or optional?

8

CFR or FOB — which Incoterm do your DRC buyers prefer?

CFR = you arrange freight. FOB = buyer arranges. Which is safer for new exporter?

9

How long does Karachi to Matadi actually take — real experience not Google?

Official = 32–37 days. Real experience may differ — vessel delays, port congestion.

10

What was your worst shipping problem — container delay, port hold, document rejection?

His worst day = your biggest lesson.

BONUS — The Most Important Question

**"Bhai, main naya exporter hoon —
aap ki jagah hote toh pehla container
kis country, kis buyer, kis mill se karte?"**

Translation: If you were me, which country, which buyer, which mill
would you choose for your first container?

This one question gets you his entire strategy in one answer.

Summary — All 5 Steps

Step 1	Registration & Certificates	10 Questions
Step 2	Bank / LC / Payment	10 Questions
Step 3	Finding Buyers	10 Questions
Step 4	Mill / Supplier Deals	10 Questions
Step 5	Shipping / Freight	10 Questions
TOTAL	Everything a New Exporter Needs	50 Questions

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